

substitute for meat; it has its own following. Because of the fermentation, it has a rich, intense umami flavour,” says Dhruv Oberoi, Executive Chef at Olive Delhi, The Grammar Room and Bar Se-rai, who has a Bolognese pasta on his menu where instead of minced beef he has used tempeh, and a cheese steak where tempeh has replaced *haloumi* to make the dish vegan.

It was in 2021 that Siddharth Ramasubramanian, Founder and

and today, it’s available pretty much at a gas station; or how pizza or pasta was introduced in India, and considered a novelty before it became commonplace,” he says. Tempeh, he feels, will go the same route, and he is beginning to see that. In just over 24 months, the company has grown to nearly 400 retail stores across the metros and tempeh is available online across the country, with purchases being made even in smaller towns like Panipat and Jabalpur.

for all things vegan. Tempeh, he says, was difficult to make. So he went to Java, Indonesia, to learn the process and got certified; he set up a tempeh manufacturing unit in 2019, and a brand called ‘Tempe Wala’. Tempe Wala is tempeh-centric but sells all kinds of probiotics. Krishnaswami sold his cloud kitchen last year and is currently pursuing his MBA from IIM Bangalore. “I still sell tempeh to the cloud kitchen. It is a profitable business,” he says. Tempeh,

**THE GLOBAL TEMPEH MARKET, PEGGED AT \$3.8 BILLION IN 2022, IS EXPECTED TO REACH \$6.3 BILLION BY 2032**



CEO of Hello Tempayy, set up his company selling ready-to-cook tempeh in Bengaluru. Having a background in hospitality and having worked in the US, Australia and Dubai, Ramasubramanian says that he had an understanding of how various cultures consumed food and how a variety of foods introduced at different times eventually became a part of mainstream culture.

When Sushi came to the US, “everybody thought it was weird

It is also sold to over 75 F&B outlets across India. “While figuring out my business plan, I realised that vegetarians had very limited options when it came to protein, *paneer* being the de facto choice. And I figured tempeh would be ideal,” says Ramasubramanian.

Vaibhav Krishnaswami had a similar idea when he set up his vegan cloud kitchen in Bengaluru in 2017 at the age of 22. With a menu of 184 dishes, it soon became a one-stop shop

he believes, is still in its nascent stage and it will be a couple of decades before the market matures. Tempe Wala has a revenue of around ₹60-70 lakh annually; of which tempeh contributes 20-25%, from just about 5-6% in the first year.

While it may still be some time before tempeh becomes as commonplace as *paneer* in Indian kitchens, it’s here to stay. **BT**

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